



SIM Card & Mobile Service

Getting a phone number, carrier plans, and registration rules

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Article 1

SIM Card Rules for Foreigners in China: One Passport, One Card, and the Cancellation Trap (2026)

Getting a SIM card in China seems simple -- walk into a carrier store, show your passport, get a card. But there's a critical rule that catches many foreigners off guard:

each foreign passport can only register one SIM card per carrier at a time

. And if you registered a card in a different city and want to cancel it, you may have to travel back to that city in person. This article explains the rules, the sources, and how to avoid getting stuck.

The Legal Basis: 工信部令第25号

The foundation of China's SIM card registration system is the

《电话用户真实身份信息登记规定》



(Provisions on Registration of Real Identity Information of Telephone Users), issued by

the

Ministry of Industry and Information Technology (MIIT/工信部)

as

Order No. 25

, effective September 1, 2013.

Key provisions:

* Article 6:

* Telecom operators must require users to present valid ID and provide real identity information when registering.

* Article 7(4):

* Foreign citizen passports (外国公民护照)

* are listed as valid identification documents for SIM card registration.



* Article 9:

* Operators must verify and record the ID type, name, number, and address from the document.

Full text:

[百度百科 -- 电话用户真实身份信息登记规定](#)

The "One SIM Per Passport" Rule

While Order No. 25 establishes real-name registration, the

one-SIM-per-passport-per-carrier

limit comes from additional anti-fraud regulations. In 2016, MIIT issued

工信部网安〔2016〕182号

, which requires carriers to limit the number of SIM cards per identity document to prevent fraud.



In practice:

- * Chinese citizens (身份证):

- * Can register up to 5 SIM cards per carrier (15 total across all three carriers)

- * Foreigners (护照/Passport):

- * Typically limited to

- * 1 SIM card per carrier

- * . Some carriers allow 2-3, but this varies by province and store policy.

- * Why stricter for foreigners?

- * Anti-fraud measures. Foreign passports are harder to verify in real-time, and the system limits exposure to potential fraud.

The Cancellation Trap: "Must Return to Original Store"

This is the policy that frustrates foreigners the most. When you want to cancel (注销) a



SIM card, the carrier may tell you that you

must go back to the original business hall (营业厅) where you registered the card

to cancel it in person.

Why does this exist?

* Each province's carrier system operates semi-independently. Your account data is stored in the provincial system where you registered.

* Cross-region cancellation requires data transfer between provincial systems, which historically wasn't supported.

* The policy prevents fraud -- someone can't cancel your SIM card at a random store without your original registration data.

Has this been fixed?

Partially. In November 2018, MIIT issued a notice requiring all three carriers to



implement

cross-region SIM cancellation (异地销户)

by January 1, 2019. However, implementation has been inconsistent:

* China Mobile:

* Supports cross-region cancellation at most flagship stores in Tier 1 cities. Call 10086

first to confirm.

* China Unicom:

* Supports cross-region cancellation at designated stores. Call 10010 to find the nearest store that handles it.

* China Telecom:

* Most limited -- still often requires return to original city. Call 10000 for guidance.

Reality check: Even with the policy change, many frontline staff still don't know how to process cross-region cancellation. You may need to escalate to a manager or call the



carrier's customer service hotline to get it done.

How to Avoid the Cancellation Trap:

- * Register your SIM in the city where you'll stay long-term.
- * Don't get a SIM in a transit city just because it's convenient at the airport.
- * Keep your SIM active.
- * If you stop paying, the carrier will eventually reclaim the number, but this takes 3-6 months and may affect your credit record with that carrier.
- * Before leaving a city,
 - * go to the carrier's flagship store and cancel in person. Bring your passport and SIM card.
 - * If you're already stuck,
 - * call the carrier's hotline (10086/10010/10000) and ask for cross-region cancellation (异地销户). Be persistent -- ask for a supervisor if the frontline agent says it's impossible.



How to Get a SIM Card: Step-by-Step

Choose a carrier.

China Mobile has the best coverage. China Unicom is best for iPhones. China Telecom is cheapest.

Find a flagship store (旗舰店).

Don't go to small authorized resellers -- they may not handle foreign passports. Use the carrier's website or app to find the nearest flagship store.

Bring:

Your passport (original, not copy), and your phone (they'll test the SIM).

Choose a plan.

Minimum plans start at ¥49-58/month with 20-30GB data. Ask for a "new user promotion" (新用户优惠) -- you'll often get extra data or a discount for the first 6-12



months.

Pay.

Monthly plans are auto-deducted via bank card or Alipay/WeChat Pay. You can also prepay at the store.

Activate.

The SIM is usually active within 1-2 hours. Some plans activate instantly.

Essential Phone Numbers:

* 10086

* -- China Mobile customer service

* 10010

* -- China Unicom customer service

* 10000



* -- China Telecom customer service

* 110

* -- Police emergency

* 120

* -- Ambulance

Sources: Sources: MIIT (工信部) • 工信部令第25号 全文 • China Mobile • China Unicom • China Telecom

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